

HEARTHBOUND HOLLOW

A Cozy Memory-Broker Narrative Simulation

"Some memories want to be sold. Some don't."

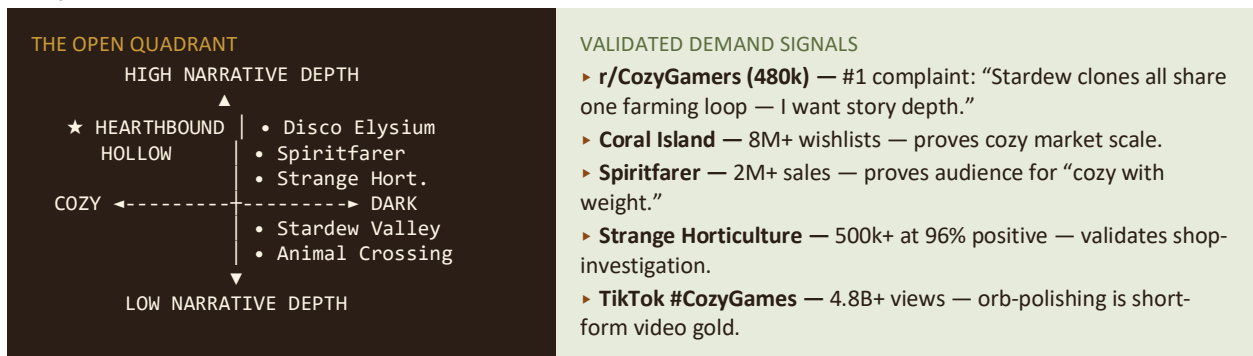
Stardew's warmth × Spiritfarer's heart × Strange Horticulture's puzzles × Disco Elysium's writing — at cozy scale

GENRE	MODE	PLATFORM	PRICE · LAUNCH
Cozy life-sim · Narrative investigation · Magical realism	Single-player · No combat · No fail-state	PC / Steam + Switch Day-1 → Mobile → PS5 / Xbox	\$24.99 base · \$9.99 mobile · Target 2027

THE PITCH IN ONE BREATH You inherit **The Hollow** — a memory-brokerage shop in a quiet autumn village, abandoned by its mysterious previous keeper. Memories are physical, glowing glass orbs you can **buy, sell, restore, and find**. Every villager carries a hand-authored life story locked in orbs — and every transaction is a choice with weight. Beneath the warmth lies one question: **why did the previous keeper vanish?**

01 The Concept & The Market Gap

Cozy games oversaturate the **farming + relationships** axis — every Stardew clone fights for the same audience. The **cozy-narrative-investigation** axis is wide open. Spiritfarer proved 2M+ players want emotional weight in cozy; Strange Horticulture proved tactile shop-investigation works. **Nobody has fused them into one premium title.**



Estimated TAM \$25–50M · conservative 3-yr projection ~\$44.7M gross / ~\$26M net · no gacha, no energy, no P2W — trust is the moat.

02 The Core Loop

One in-game day ≈ 20–35 min. Calm, repeatable, hand-authored — never grindy.

1. MORNING Tend the shop, polish jars, brew tea.	2. OPEN SHOP Villagers visit with one of four needs.	3. WORKBENCH Polish · Cleanse · Weave · Sever orbs.	4. VILLAGE WALK Deliver memories, harvest herbs, talk.	5. EVENING LEDGER Review the day; keep / sell / experience. Saves.	ZZZ 6. MEMORY DREAM Sleep into an illustrated narrative vignette.
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→ → → the cycle loops, and the village quietly changes around your choices ↻

 TO SELL a painful memory they want to be rid of	 TO BUY a memory they yearn for but never lived	 TO RESTORE a memory that has faded and cracked	 TO FIND a memory someone else lost or stole
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Every visitor arrives with one of these four needs — the engine of every day.

03 The Pillar Mechanics

Five interlocking systems. Tactile over textual — if a feeling can be felt through an orb, prefer it over text.

A Memory Orbs — the tactile core

Memories take physical form as glass orbs you physically drag, sort, polish, and weave on your shelves. Four readable properties tell you everything before a single word of dialogue:

- **Colour** = emotional tone (joy, grief, shame, awe, longing, dread...)
- **Clarity** = how intact the memory is
- **Cracks** = trauma — cleanse carelessly and you erase the truth
- **Weight** = significance to the person who gave it

B The Workbench — the crafting core

Four operations, each a short (<90s) tactile mini-game with an always-visible “do it for me” auto-complete. Every villager has unique tolerances — some want grief cleansed; others would never forgive you for taking it.

- **Polish** — restore clarity to a faded orb (slow circular motion)
- **Cleanse** — remove cracks/trauma (pattern trace) · risk: erase too much
- **Weave** — combine two memories into one stronger memory (tessellation)
- **Sever** — split a complex memory into its components (reverse tessellation)

C The Echo Web & Village Ledger — the narrative core

Every villager hides a **Memory Map** — 12–20 memories that reconstruct their whole life. Orbs carry hidden **Echoes** (shared faces, places, objects, years); collecting linked memories lights a thread between them in your Codex and unlocks **Revelation chapters**. Doris's wedding-day crowd hides a face from the Mayor's first regret — and the whole village is one woven thing.

D The Moral Compass — the 7 Vows / the choice core

Unlike farming sims, **every transaction is a choice**. A widower asks you to erase his late wife — do you? A lonely child wants to buy a stranger's father-memory. The Keeper lives by **seven Vows** (Consent · Return · Whole · Quiet Glass · Honest Coin · Open Door · Last Light). Vows aren't a morality bar — they quietly shape how every villager responds to you over seasons.

E Memory Tea & The Garden — the cozy anchor

A small herb garden behind the Hollow (lavender, valerian, sage, mugwort...). Brew teas that help villagers open up — or temporarily forget. This is the comfort/idle loop that lets the game breathe between heavy moments.

04 Progression — How The Game Grows

Replayable on emotion, not grind. New playthroughs explore different residents, not new mechanics.

Progress is woven from people, not XP bars. The game silently tracks a 14-dimension Village State (per-villager Trust, Memory Integrity, the 7 Vow integrities, Pickle's approval, Coin & Cinder, Hollow level, Echo connections, the predecessor trail...). You never see a number — you infer the consequence.

WHAT DEEPENS AS YOU PLAY

MISSION ARC (THE LONG ROAD)

- ◆ Villager Trust & their Memory Maps fill in
- ◆ Vow integrities shift, re-shaping the village
- ◆ The Echo Web threads more memories together
- ◆ Hollow upgrades + a 2nd progression track (Garden)
- ◆ The Coin & Cinder economy (Cinder = Listen-path only)
- ◆ The grand mystery of the predecessor, Marin

- ▶ **M1 · Opening the Hollow** — meet Doris · polish your first orb
✓ playable
- ▶ **M2 · The Widower's Request** — Gerrold · the first moral choice
✓ playable
- ▶ **M3–M10** — 30+ villagers · Weave/Sever · seasons
▣ post-greenlight
- ▶ **Full game** — the predecessor revealed · ~45–60 hrs
▣ scaling ref

THE VERTICAL SLICE TODAY A fully playable, polished **Mission 1 + Mission 2** in Unity 6 — six scenes, two villager arcs, four moral choices, two Memory Dreams, full comfort/accessibility layer. ~55–75 minutes of cozy. Build v0.5.0. Next gate: a 20-person greenlight playtest (target: 14/20 say “I want to play more”).

05 How To Play — A Guide For The Director

The complete mechanical vocabulary of the playable slice. No HUD. No combat. Tension is moral, not mechanical.

THE CORE VERBS — everything you actually do

 Walk	Camera-relative WASD / stick. Slow autumn pace. Sprint + Jump (off in Gentle Mode).
 Listen	Watch the speaker; pick 1 of 2–6 options that almost always include “(silent nod).” You never have to speak first.
 Examine	Press E near any glowing prop to read its codex tooltip. Many props seed the long-arc story.
 Polish	Hold to draw slow circles over a faded orb; the memory clears as you work (~70–90s).
 Brew	Harvest a herb → steep at the kettle → pour → carry the cup. ~12 real seconds of warmth.
 Cleanse	Trace each crack without crossing the warm core (~70–100s). Real consequences, never a “FAILED” screen.
 Choose	Read four sentences in fiction-voice; press a button. The heaviest choice asks you to confirm twice.
 Sleep / Close the Ledger	Close a leather-bound book at day's end — that is the only save. A dream plays. Morning comes.

KEY CONTROLS

Move **WASD / Stick**
 Interact / Examine **E / □**
 Polish · Cleanse **Hold LMB + draw**
 Camera look / zoom **RMB drag / scroll**
 Open Codex (Memory Map) **C**
 Help card / Pause **H / Esc**
 Skip cutscene **Hold Space 0.8s**

THE COZY CONTRACT — six promises

1. Nothing punishes kindness.
2. Failure is narratively absorbed, never scored.
3. No time pressure unless you ask for it.
4. Refusal is always honoured — sometimes it's the best path.
5. No content surprises (the Tone Compass warns you first).
6. Auto-Complete is always available for every mini-game.

 **MEET PICKLE** A slate-grey, sarcastic, telepathic cat — the only living thing the previous Keeper left behind. She judges every decision, but you only earn her commentary by being kind. **Plus:** Gentle Mode, Auto-Complete, colour-blind & dyslexia options, per-character voice sliders, and Heavy-Theme warning cards — comfort is first-class, and nothing ever locks you out of content.

06 Why It Wins — USPs & Director's Takeaways

 A novel core mechanic Memories as a physical, tradable commodity — never attempted at this depth. Tactile, dramatic, replayable, and engineered for short-form video.	 Cozy with real weight Every transaction has lasting village consequences. The cozy crowd that cried at Spiritfarer is waiting for this.	 Every villager is a mystery 30+ residents, each a hand-authored, fully reconstructable memory map — depth without farming grind.
 Memory Dreams Every collected memory becomes a branching illustrated vignette — perpetual, low-cost narrative content.	 No combat. No death. No grind. Clean positioning against farming-sim fatigue; tension is purely moral.	 A grand mystery underneath Who was the previous Keeper, and why did they leave? The thread that pulls players to the end.
<i>“The shop should feel like a real place. The villagers should feel like real people. The choices should hurt a little. And the soundtrack should make people cry on the bus.”</i> — The Hearthbound Hollow vision		

Distilled from GAME_DESIGN.md · SUMMARY_EN.md · GAMEPLAY_GUIDE_OVERVIEW.md · README.md · Depth Bible · Abdulmalek-Agents /
hearthbound-hollow

Concept Brief prepared for the Game Director · Narrative Director · Lead Game Designer · UX/UI · 2D/UI Art · QA-approved